Who can afford to rent in Toronto?

Why the same city can mean very different housing pressure

Income. Rental costs. Housing support.

2011

Detailed rental story

2016

Newer housing overview

Historical neighbourhood data supplied for the course. Prepared October 2026.

What makes renting harder to afford?

This project looks at how rental costs, household income and housing support vary across Toronto neighbourhoods.

The key distinction

An expensive area is not always the area where renters face the most financial pressure.

01

Understand the bill

Start with a simple budget example.

02

Find the pressure

Use the map to see where renters cross 30%.

03

Explore the reasons

Read the income and housing-support charts.

Then compare two neighbourhoods and check the newer 2016 overview.

The charts describe neighbourhood patterns. They do not reveal why individual residents moved.

Price is only part of the story

01

Income changes what a bill means

A $1,200 housing bill takes 40% of a $3,000 income and 20% of a $6,000 income.

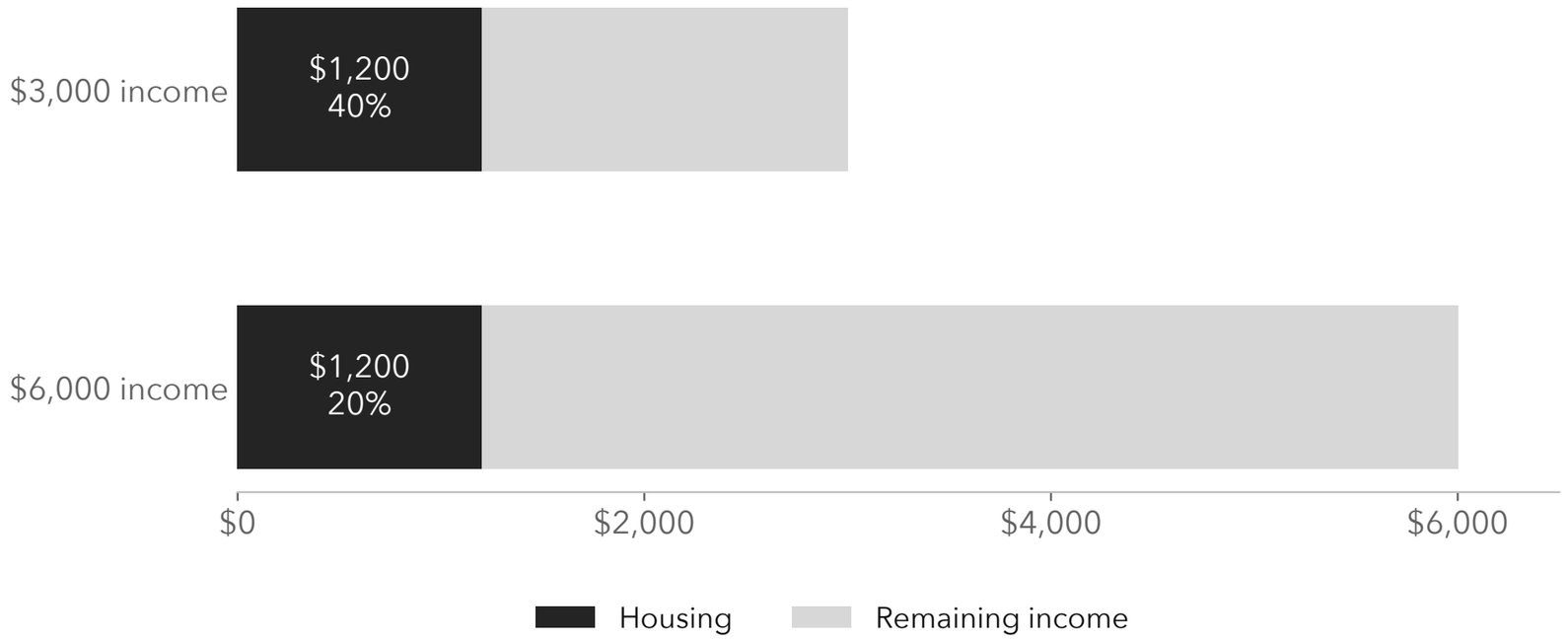
02

Housing support helps explain lower costs

Regent Park combines more housing support with lower rental costs. The pattern suggests an explanation, but does not prove a cause.

The data describe housing conditions. They do not tell us why people chose a neighbourhood.

First, what does affordability mean?



$3,783

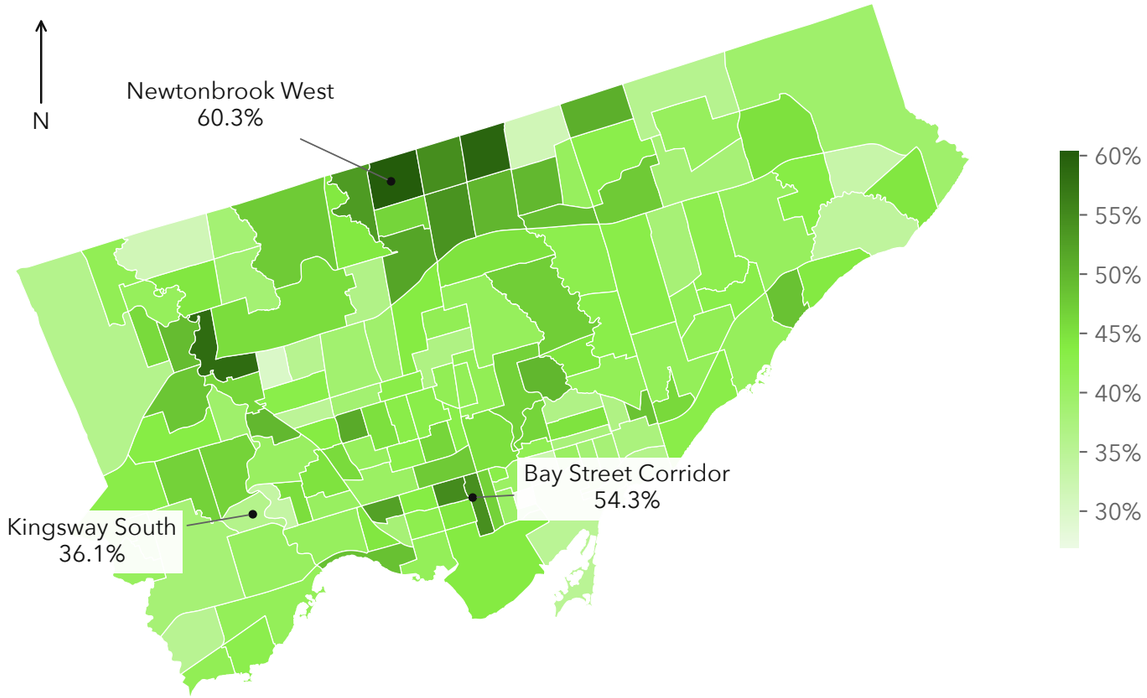
Monthly gross income needed to keep a $1,135 housing bill at 30%

The $1,135 bill is Newtonbrook West's 2011 rental average. The income is a calculated benchmark.

Look at the dark part of each bar: the housing bill is the same. A lower income leaves less money for everything else. This is why price alone cannot explain affordability.

Illustrative budgets, not measured households. The files do not pair each renter's own income with their housing bill.

Where is renting harder to afford?



60.3%

Newtonbrook West renters paying 30%+ of income on housing

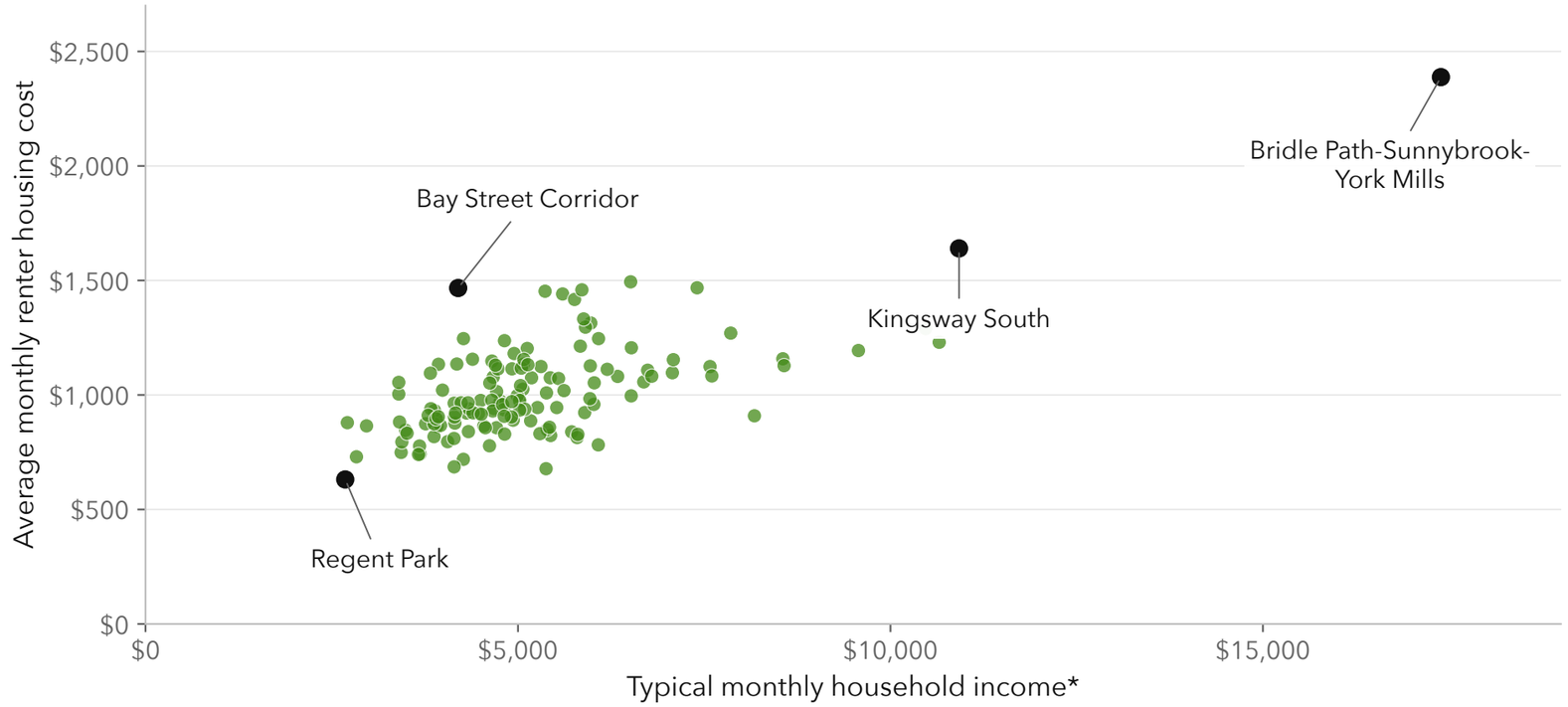
36.1%

Kingsway South renters at the same threshold

Start with the darkest areas. They have more renters spending at least $30 of every $100 of income on housing. Compare the two labelled examples.

Source: supplied City of Toronto 2011 neighbourhood Census/NHS file. Rental housing costs include applicable utilities.

Higher income, higher rental costs



Read left to right for income and bottom to top for rental costs. The dots tend to rise together. Income here includes owners and renters.

KINGSWAY SOUTH

$10,921

Typical monthly household income

$1,640 rental housing cost

BAY STREET CORRIDOR

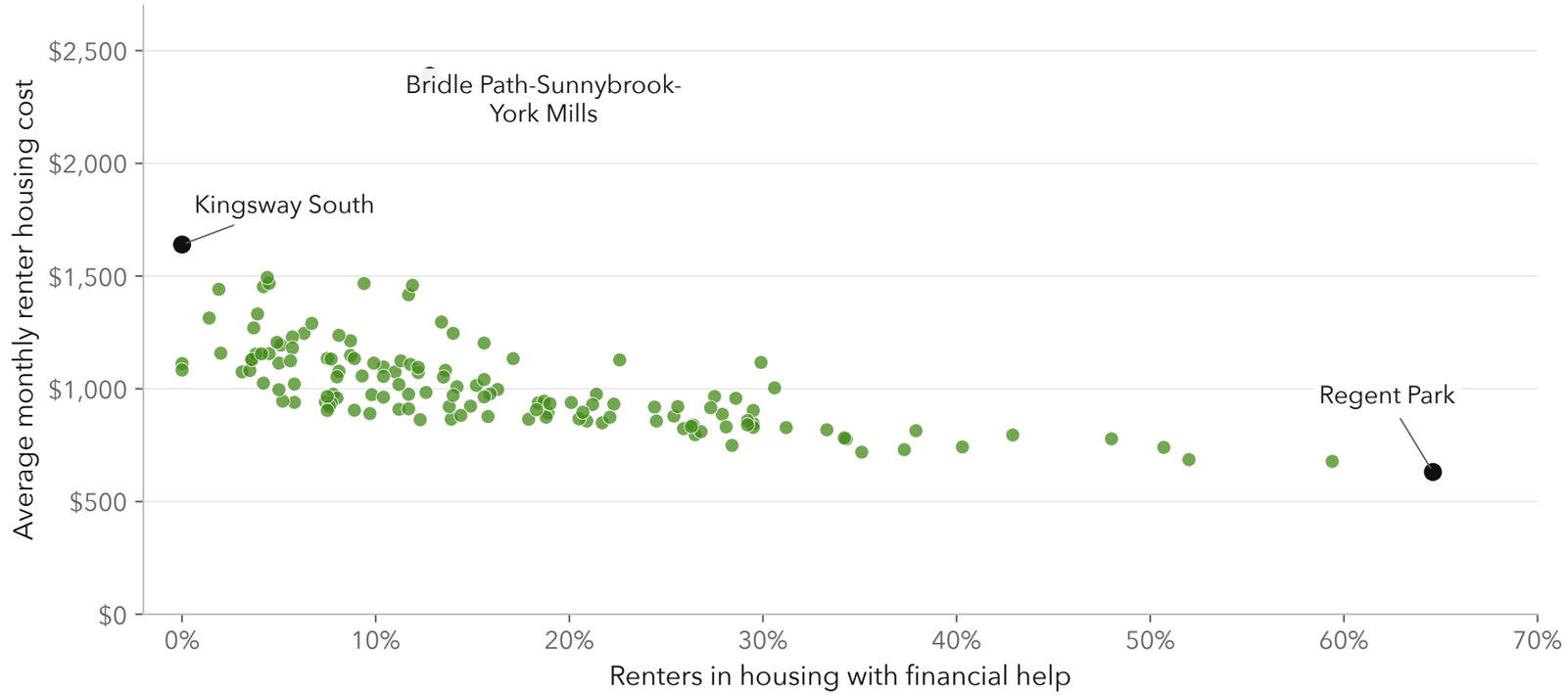
$4,197

Typical monthly household income

$1,467 rental housing cost

Source: supplied City of Toronto 2011 neighbourhood Census/NHS file. Rental housing costs include applicable utilities. Income = annual median / 12, before tax, for owners and renters. It is not renter-specific.

More housing support, lower costs



Read left to right for housing support. Costs tend to fall as support rises. This is a pattern across areas, not proof that support alone caused it.

64.6%

Regent Park renters in housing with financial help

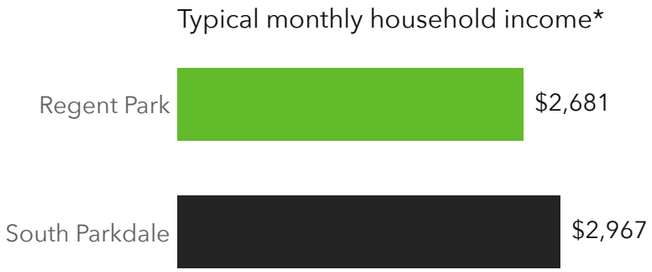
$631

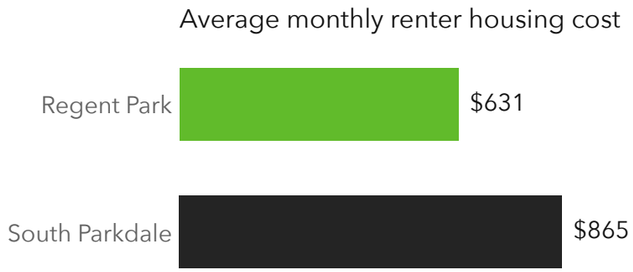
Average monthly renter housing cost in Regent Park

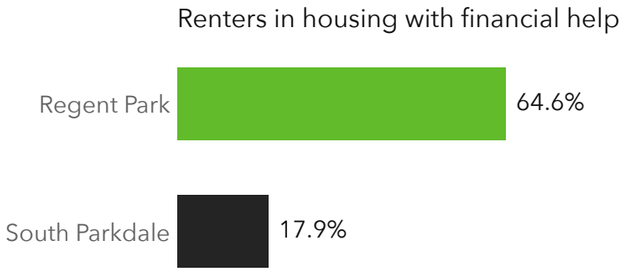
Housing help includes reduced rents, public housing and support with rent.

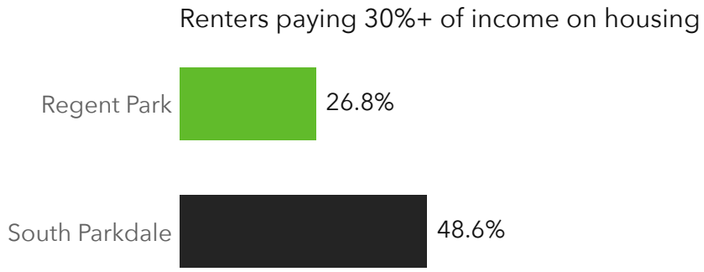
Source: supplied City of Toronto 2011 neighbourhood Census/NHS file. Rental housing costs include applicable utilities.

Regent Park and South Parkdale







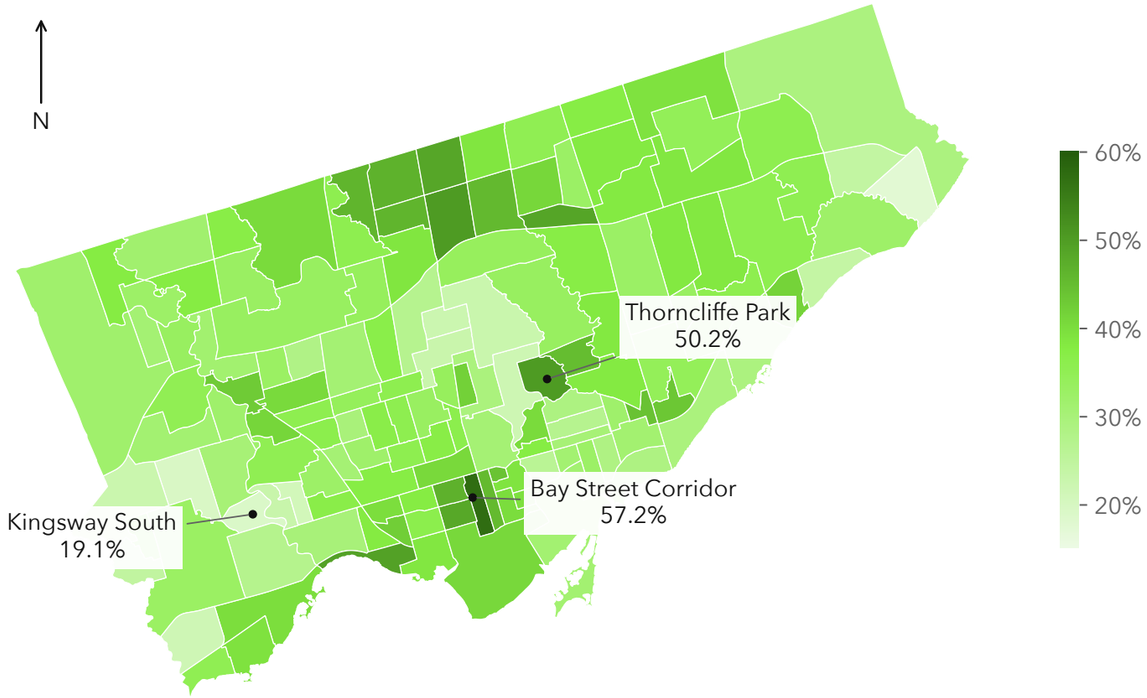


$234 less per month

Regent Park has lower average rental costs and 21.8 percentage points fewer renters crossing the 30% threshold than South Parkdale.

Source: supplied City of Toronto 2011 neighbourhood Census/NHS file. Rental housing costs include applicable utilities. Household income includes owners and renters. Other measures cover renters.

A newer view of housing pressure



This 2016 view covers owners and renters together. It cannot show change from the 2011 renter-only map.

36.6%

Toronto-wide share of assessed households paying 30%+ of income on housing

57.2%

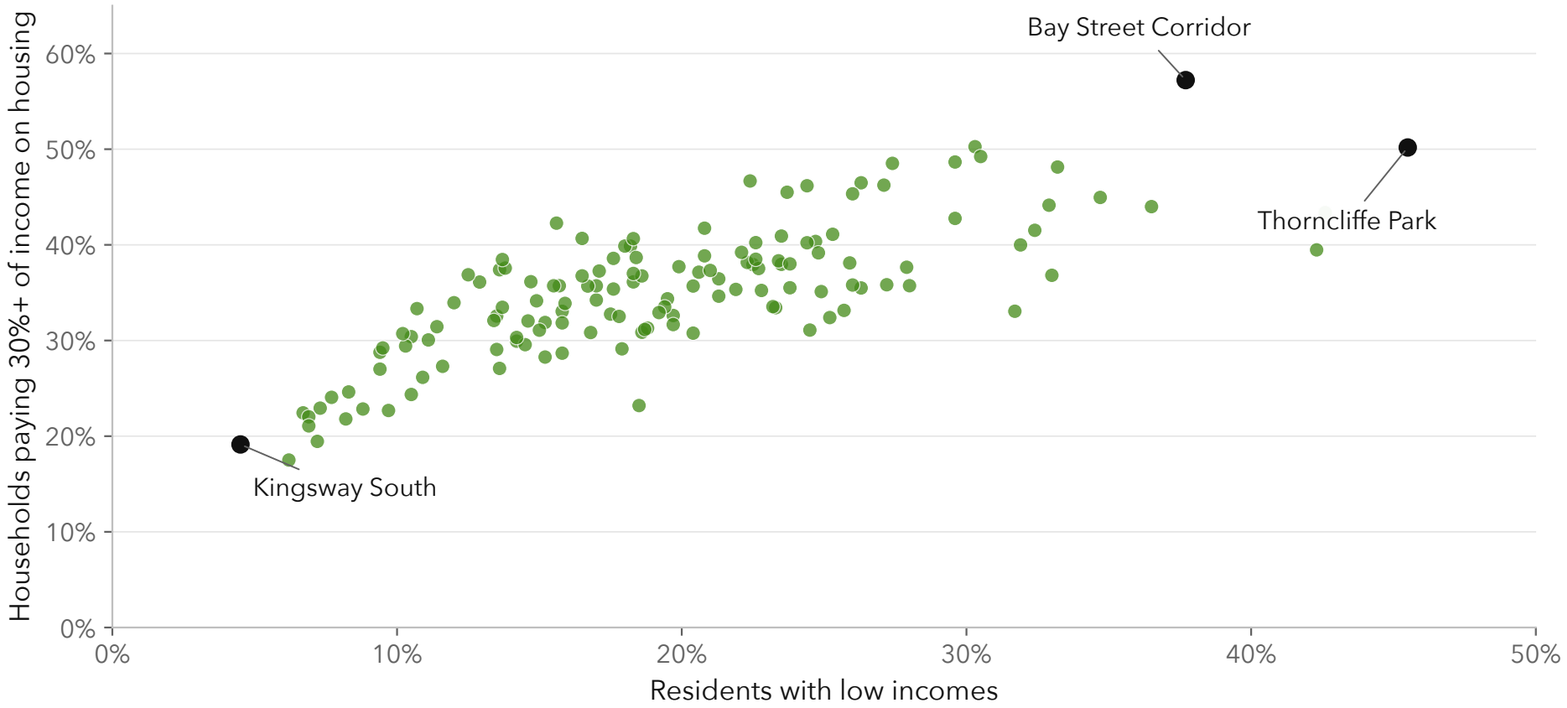
Bay Street Corridor

19.1%

Kingsway South

Source: supplied City of Toronto 2016 neighbourhood Census file. Assessed households include owners and renters.

Low income and housing pressure



Start at the bottom left and follow the dots upward. Areas with more low-income residents generally have more households above the 30% housing-cost threshold.

WHAT THE DOTS SHOW

Low income and housing pressure tend to be higher in the same areas.

Each dot represents a neighbourhood. It does not link a person's income to their own housing bill.

Source: supplied City of Toronto 2016 neighbourhood Census file. Assessed households include owners and renters. Low-income status uses 2015 income.

To understand affordability, look beyond the price.

01

Income changes what people can afford

The same housing bill can take a very different share of a household income.

02

Housing support is part of the picture

Areas with more support tend to have lower rental costs. Regent Park illustrates this pattern.

03

The pressure varies across Toronto

Both the maps and the newer overview show that the financial pressure is uneven.

These patterns offer possible explanations. They do not establish a cause or describe individual renter budgets.

What the numbers mean

Monthly rental cost	Average rent and applicable utilities. Covers renters in 2011.
Typical monthly income	Annual median household income divided by 12, before tax. Includes owners and renters.
Housing support	Rent-geared-to-income housing, public housing and other financial help for renters.
30%+ housing share	Households spending 30%+ of total income on housing. Renter-only in 2011. Assessed owners and renters in 2016.
Read the years separately	2011 used a voluntary survey. The supplied 2016 file lacks neighbourhood rental costs and median household income. These views cannot establish why people moved or what caused the differences.

Production note: the PDF figures redraw cleaned data. Tableau exports remain needed for the course submission.

How I found a clearer question

01

I started with price

I first wanted to know where in Toronto it was most expensive to live. As I explored the idea, I realised this was too broad. A high price did not tell me who could afford it.

02

I explored the data

I tried different maps and charts and compared rental costs, income and housing support. This helped me move from showing expensive places to looking at financial pressure.

03

I simplified the data

I kept the fields that helped answer the question, used clearer labels and checked the neighbourhood matches. I made the dollar amounts and percentages consistent and left missing values blank.

04

I narrowed the story

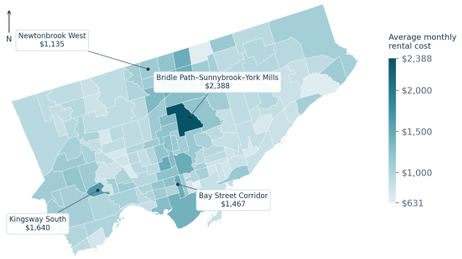
I focused on why renting can be harder to afford in some neighbourhoods. I used the map to show where, then added income, housing support and a simple comparison to help explain the patterns.

The main story uses 2011 because it has the needed rental detail. The newer 2016 overview stays separate.

Preparation included monthly income = annual median / 12, readable percentage formats and a check of 140 neighbourhood matches.

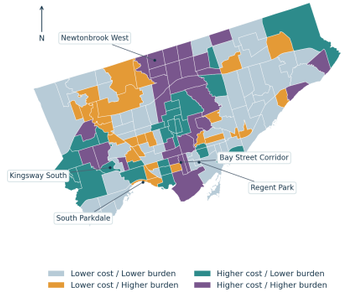
How the visual story changed

01 My first question



I began by mapping rental prices. It showed expensive places, but left the question of affordability open.

02 A more focused question



I then added the share of renters spending 30%+ of income on housing. This revealed a different pattern.

03 Build the explanation

Income, housing support and a neighbourhood comparison add context. A simple budget example makes affordability easier to understand.

Sources

Neighbourhood profiles

Historical boundaries

2011 housing definitions

Working data: supplied edited 2006, 2011 and 2016 files. Main rental story uses 2011. Newer overview uses 2016.

Development examples are earlier drafts from this project. Source links are clickable.

Toronto rental affordability

Figure explanations

The map shows where renters face more housing pressure. The dot chart adds income and rental costs, and the Regent Park and South Parkdale comparison shows how housing support may help explain the differences.

1. Where renting puts more pressure on income

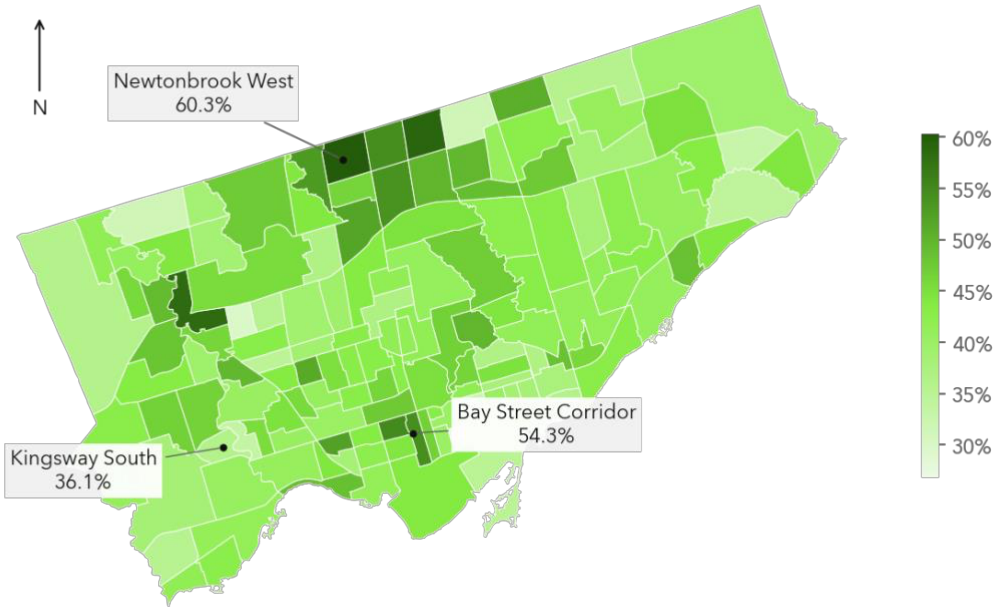


Figure 1. Toronto neighbourhood profiles, 2011. Darker green means more renters spend at least 30% of income on housing.

This map shows where renters in Toronto spend a large share of their income on housing. Each area is a neighbourhood. The darker the green, the more renter households spend at least 30% of their income on housing. That means housing takes at least $30 out of every $100 they earn. Newtonbrook West stands out at 60.3%, compared with 36.1% in Kingsway South. Put simply, about 60 out of 100 renter households in Newtonbrook West crossed that mark, compared with about 36 in Kingsway South. Bay Street Corridor is also high at 54.3%. The difference matters because the most expensive place to rent is not always the place where renters face the most pressure. What people earn and what help they receive also shape what they can afford. The map gives us the starting point, it shows where the pressure is higher. It does not tell us why every household is struggling or why people chose to live there. The dot chart on the next page adds income to the picture. The final comparison then brings rental costs and housing support together. These figures describe conditions in 2011, rather than rental prices today.

2. How income and rental costs fit together

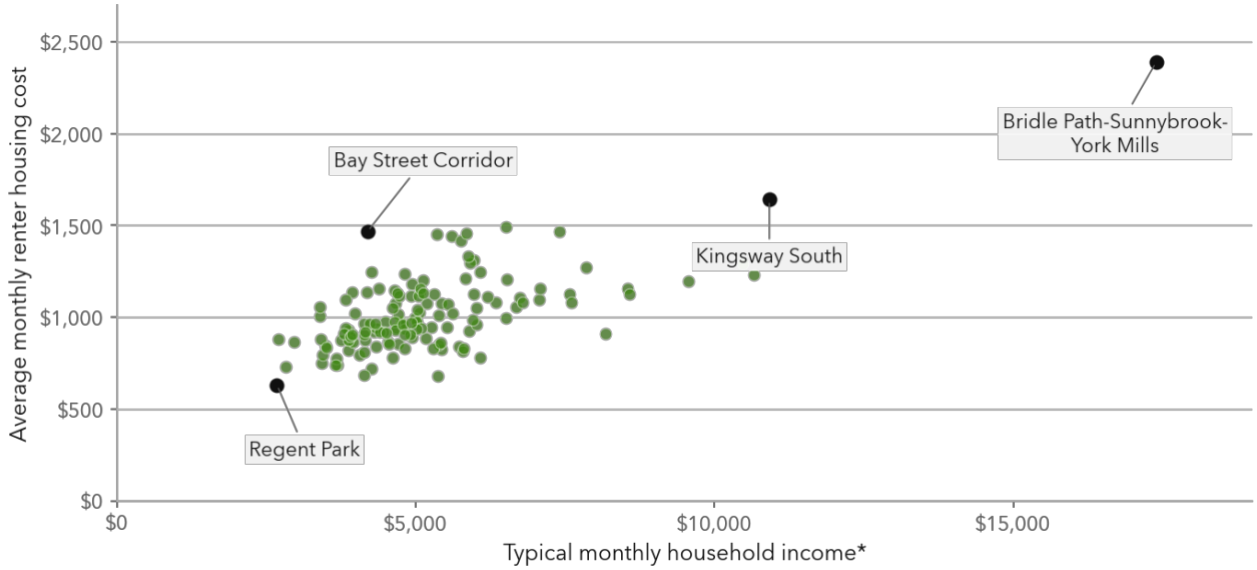


Figure 2. Toronto neighbourhood profiles, 2011. Typical monthly income is annual median household income divided by 12, before tax, using 2010 income.

Each dot in this chart is a Toronto neighbourhood. Moving to the right means a higher typical monthly household income. Moving up means a higher average monthly rental housing cost. Most dots rise as they move right, so neighbourhoods with higher incomes tend to have higher rental costs. But the named examples show why the relationship needs a closer look. Kingsway South has a typical monthly household income of about $10,921 and an average rental housing cost of $1,640. Bay Street Corridor has a much lower typical income of about $4,197, while its rental housing cost is still $1,467. The rental costs are fairly close, but the income figures are far apart. This gives the map more context: a price that looks similar on paper can sit within very different income conditions. There is one limit to keep in mind. The income figures include owners and renters, while the housing costs cover renters. We cannot divide these numbers to work out what an actual renter spends from their income. The chart shows a neighbourhood pattern, not individual budgets. It also leaves another question open: what helps explain lower rental costs in some lower-income areas? The Regent Park and South Parkdale comparison adds housing support to that picture.

3 Why Regent Park and South Parkdale look different

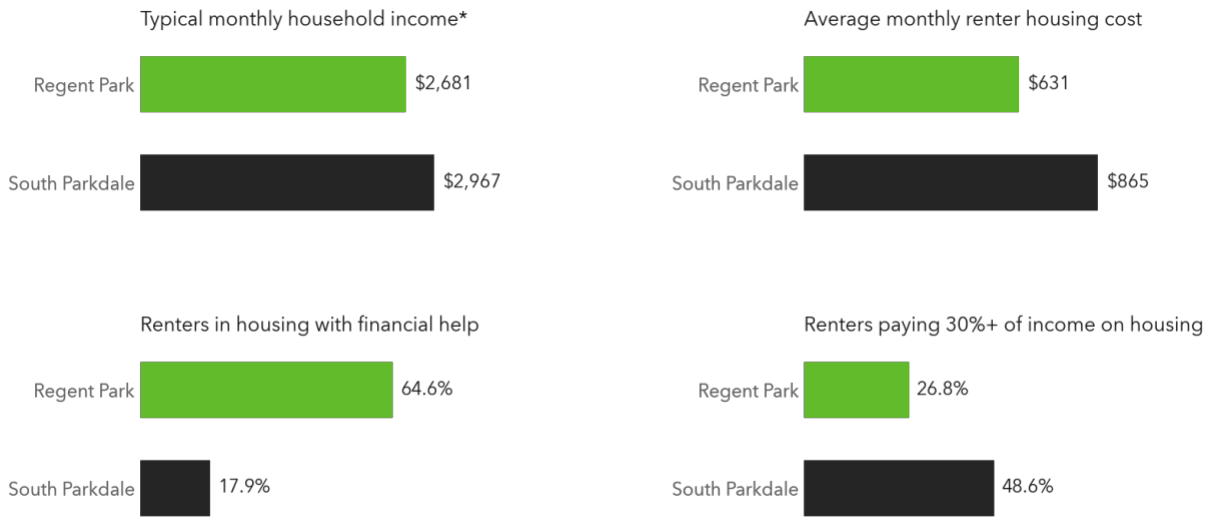


Figure 3. Toronto neighbourhood profiles, 2011. Income includes owners and renters. The other measures describe renter households.

This comparison helps explain why rental prices alone do not tell the whole story. Regent Park has a slightly lower typical monthly household income than South Parkdale: about $2,681 compared with $2,967. But its average monthly rental housing cost is also lower, at $631 rather than $865. That is $234 less each month. There is another clear difference. In Regent Park, 64.6% of renter households live in housing with financial help, compared with 17.9% in South Parkdale. Regent Park also has a smaller share of renters spending at least 30% of income on housing: 26.8%, compared with 48.6%. So even though its typical household income is lower, fewer renters cross that housing-cost mark. Lower housing costs and more support may help explain the difference. The comparison does not prove that support alone caused it, because the homes and households in each area also differ. And the income figures include owners and renters, so they cannot be used to calculate an actual renter budget. Together with the map, these bars make the main point clear: to understand where renting is harder to afford, we need to look at what people pay, their income and the help available to them.